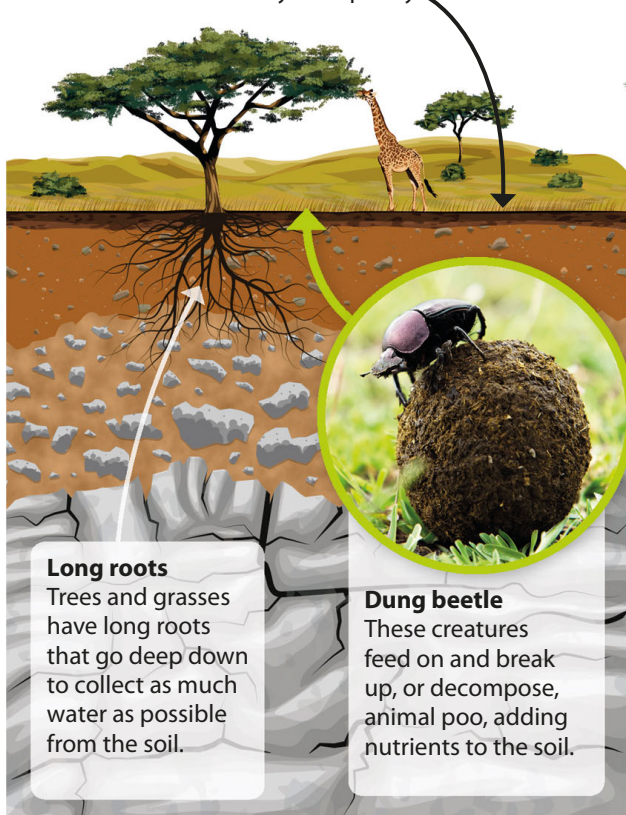


Soil

Soil is the layer of loose material between the surface and the solid rock below the ground. Nothing can grow on Earth without it, but the soil varies in different places.

Grasses

The soil is rich in nutrients, so many grasses can grow healthily and quickly.



Long roots

Trees and grasses have long roots that go deep down to collect as much water as possible from the soil.

Dung beetle

These creatures feed on and break up, or decompose, animal poo, adding nutrients to the soil.

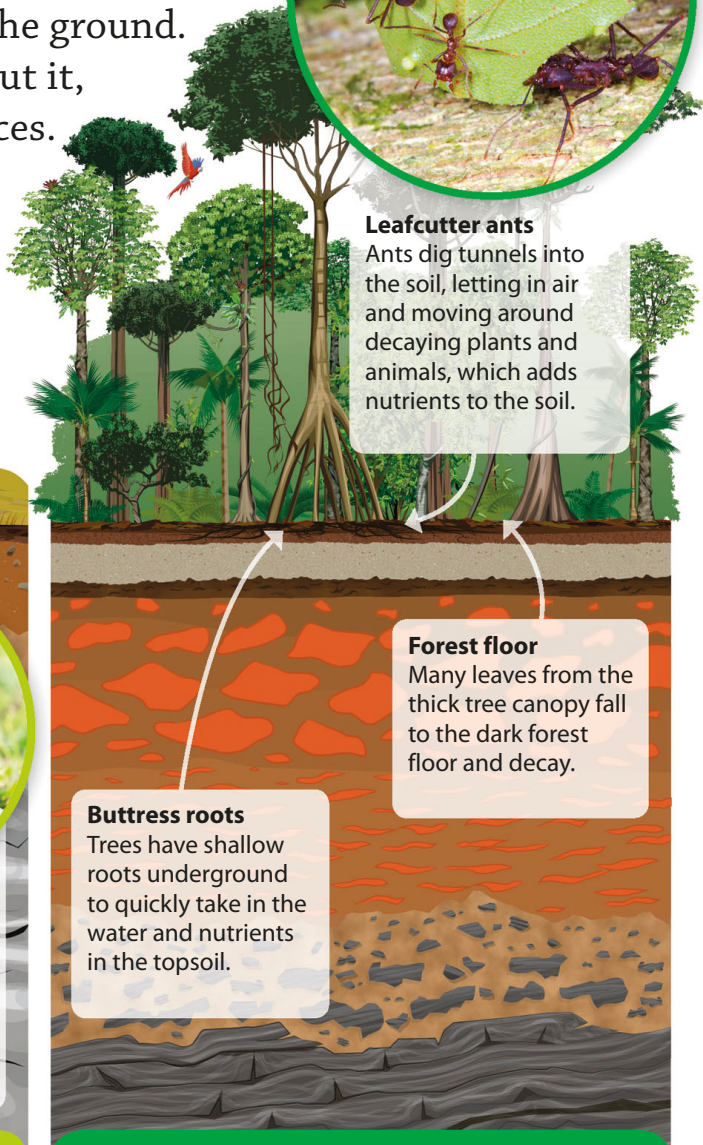
Grassland

The soil is usually deep and full of nutrients. This is because rotting grass roots help to hold the soil together and add nutrients for new plants. Plants compete for water.



Leafcutter ants

Ants dig tunnels into the soil, letting in air and moving around decaying plants and animals, which adds nutrients to the soil.



Forest floor

Many leaves from the thick tree canopy fall to the dark forest floor and decay.

Buttress roots

Trees have shallow roots underground to quickly take in the water and nutrients in the topsoil.

Tropical rainforest

The soil is very wet and many plants grow, so there is lots of humus to add nutrients to the soil. However, these nutrients are washed away by the constant rain, leaving shallow, acidic soil.